SEQUENCE 7

# One-variable descriptive statistics

7–18 December 2026

## 7.1 Frequencies, relative frequencies and mean

**Key point · Definitions.** A data set describes a characteristic over a population. If the value $x_i$ appears $n_i$ times, $n_i$ is its frequency count. The nonzero total count is $N = \sum_{i=1}^{p} n_i$; its relative frequency is $f_i = n_i/N$. The mean is

$$\overline{x} = \frac{\sum_{i=1}^{p} n_i x_i}{N} = \sum_{i=1}^{p} f_i x_i.$$

The range is $x_{\max} - x_{\min}$.

**Example 1 · Shoe sizes – booklet data.** We study the shoe sizes of 30 students:

| | | | | | | | | | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 36 | 42 | 40 | 41 | 41 | 38 | 39 | 43 | 42 | 42 | 42 | 40 | 36 | 40 | 39 |
| 41 | 40 | 38 | 44 | 42 | 40 | 42 | 43 | 38 | 43 | 36 | 41 | 41 | 44 | 43 |

Complete the counts, calculate the relative frequencies, the mean and the range.

| Size | 36 | 37 | 38 | 39 | 40 | 41 | 42 | 43 | 44 |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Count | ..... | ..... | ..... | ..... | ..... | ..... | ..... | ..... | ..... |



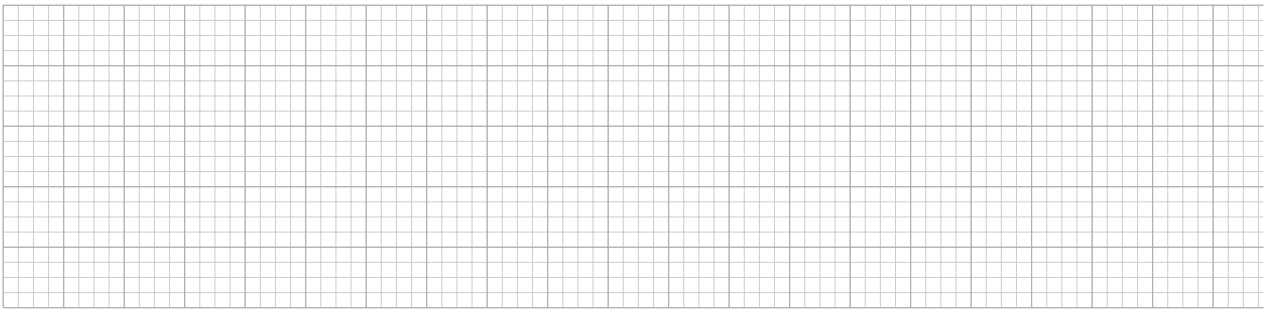
## 7.2 Median and cumulative counts

**Key point · Definition and convention.** A median is a number such that at least half of the values are less than or equal to it, and at least half are greater than or equal to it. In the ordered data set of $N$ values, if $N$ is odd, take the value of rank $(N+1)/2$; if $N$ is even, choose the mean of the values of ranks $N/2$ and $N/2+1$.

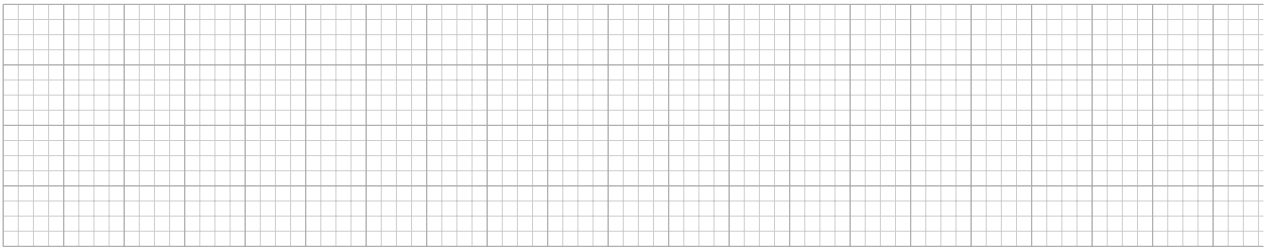
**Watch out.** With repeated values, more than 50% of the values can be less than or equal to the median.

**Example 2.** Complete the ascending cumulative counts (ACC) of the shoe sizes and determine the median.

| Size | 36 | 37 | 38 | 39 | 40 | 41 | 42 | 43 | 44 |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Count | 3 | 0 | 3 | 2 | 5 | 5 | 6 | 4 | 2 |
| ACC | ..... | ..... | ..... | ..... | ..... | ..... | ..... | ..... | ..... |



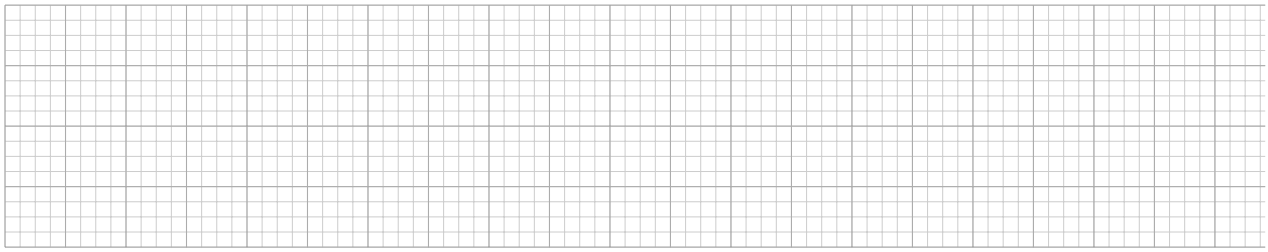
**Example 3.** Calculate the medians of 1; 2; 2; 8; 9 and of 1; 2; 8; 9.

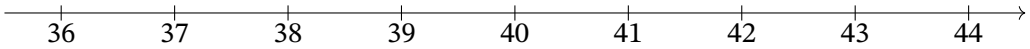


## 7.3 Quartiles and box plot

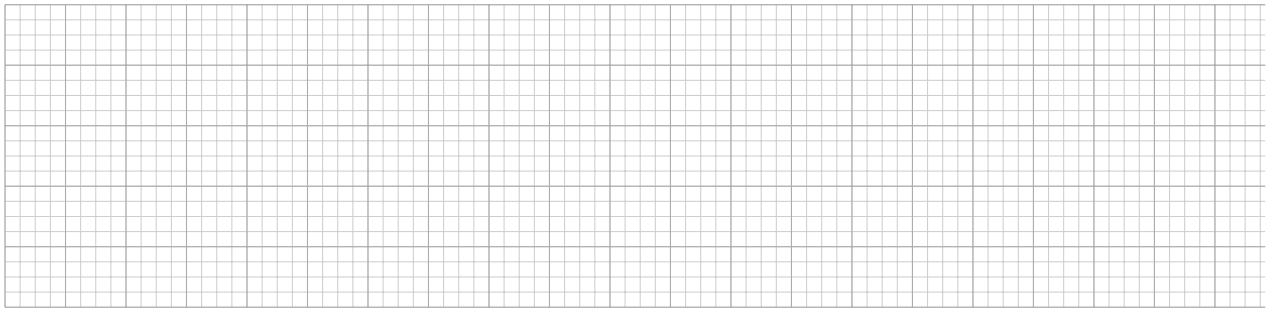
**Key point · Definitions.** The first quartile $Q_1$ is the value of rank $\lceil N/4 \rceil$: the smallest value of the data set such that at least 25% of the values are less than or equal to it. $Q_3$ is the value of rank $\lceil 3N/4 \rceil$. The interquartile range is $Q_3 - Q_1$. The box plot shows the minimum, $Q_1$, the median, $Q_3$ and the maximum.

**Example 4.** Determine $Q_1$, $Q_3$ and the interquartile range of the shoe sizes, then draw the box plot.






**Example 5.** Determine the quartiles of 1; 2; 2; 3; 4; 4; 4; 5. Are exactly 25% of the values less than or equal to $Q_1$?

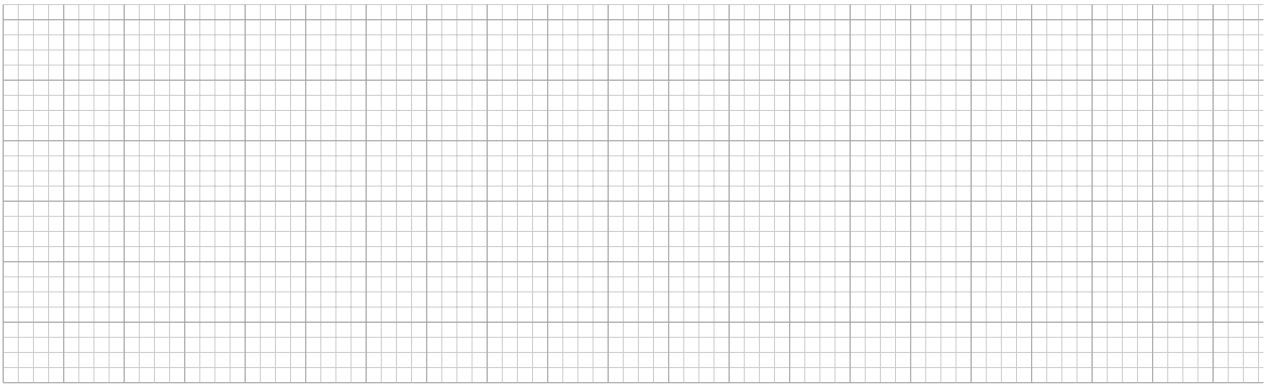


## 7.4 Adding or removing a value

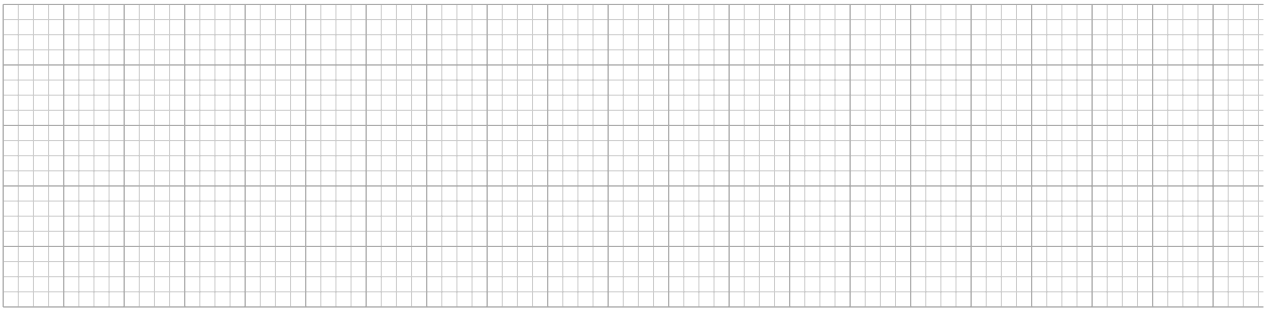
**Key point · Properties.** Adding $a$ to a data set of size $N$ gives $\overline{x}' = (N\overline{x} + a)/(N + 1)$. Removing one occurrence of $a$, for $N > 1$, gives $\overline{x}' = (N\overline{x} - a)/(N - 1)$. Use the exact sum, with no intermediate rounding. Re-examine the median in the new ordered data set.

**Example 6.** In the shoe-size data, the sum is 1217 and the median 41.

1. Add a size 36 and calculate the new statistics.
2. Starting again from the initial data, remove a size 44 and repeat.



**Example 7.** Justify that adding the mean does not change the mean. Can the range decrease when a value is added?



## 7.5 Variance and standard deviation

**Key point · Definitions.** $V = \dfrac{\sum n_i(x_i - \overline{x})^2}{N}$ is the variance; $\sigma = \sqrt{V}$ is the standard deviation. It measures the spread around the mean and has the same unit as the data. One can also compute $V = \dfrac{\sum n_i x_i^2}{N} - \overline{x}^2$.

**Example 8.** Calculate the variance and the standard deviation of the shoe sizes.

**Example 9.** Compare $A$ : $8; 10; 12$ and $B$ : $0; 10; 20$ using the mean–standard deviation pair and the median–interquartile range pair.

## 7.6 Linearity of the mean

**Key point · Property.** Replacing each $x_i$ by $kx_i + c$ gives a mean $k\overline{x} + c$, a standard deviation $|k|\sigma$ and a variance $k^2V$. Adding a constant changes neither variance nor standard deviation.

**Example 10.** Initial mean 12/20, standard deviation 3. Calculate the new statistics for three independent modifications, with no capping of marks: add 1.5; multiply by 0.8; multiply by 1.1 then add 0.5.

```
from math import sqrt

def moyenne_ecart_type(valeurs):
    n = len(valeurs)
    if n == 0:
        raise ValueError("liste vide")
    m = sum(valeurs)/n
    v = sum((x-m)**2 for x in valeurs)/n
    return m, sqrt(v)
```

**Example 11.** Explain the program; predict its result for `[8, 10, 12]`.

## 7.7 Continuous data grouped into classes

**Key point · Definitions and loss of information.** A continuous quantitative variable can take every value in an interval. Here, the observations are grouped into classes of equal width; the centre of $[a, b)$ is $(a+b)/2$. If the class means $m_i$ are known, the exact overall mean is $\sum n_i m_i / N$. Otherwise, replacing them by the centres gives an estimate justified by a uniform model within each class.

**Example 12 · Heights – booklet data.** Complete, estimate the mean from the centres and determine the median class.

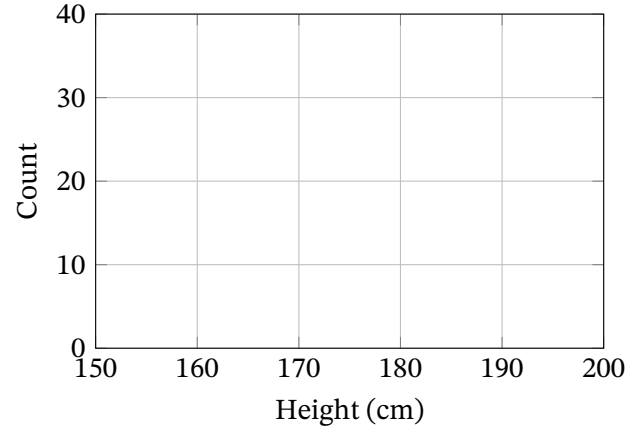
| Class (cm) | $[150, 160)$ | $[160, 170)$ | $[170, 180)$ | $[180, 190)$ | $[190, 200)$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Count | 8 | 22 | 35 | 28 | 7 |
| Relative frequency (%) | ..... | ..... | ..... | ..... | ..... |
| Centre (cm) | ..... | ..... | ..... | ..... | ..... |
| ACC | ..... | ..... | ..... | ..... | ..... |

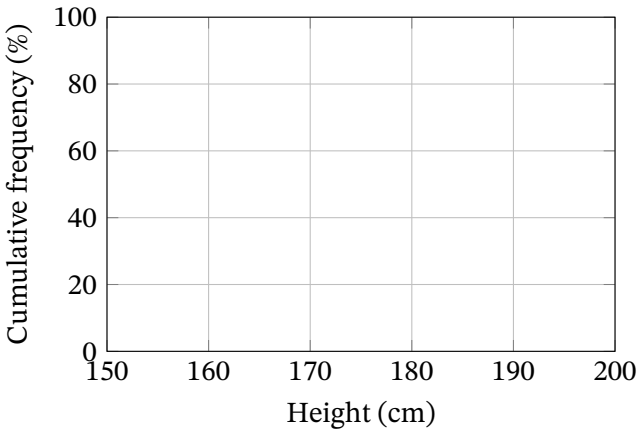
**Example 13.** If the exact class means were 154; 166; 174; 184; 196 cm, what would the overall mean be?

## 7.8 Histogram and cumulative frequencies

**Key point · Representations.** The area of each rectangle of a histogram is proportional to the count. For equal widths, the heights can be the counts. The cumulative frequency polygon joins the points (upper bound; cumulative frequency), starting at the first lower bound with 0.

**Example 14.** Construct both graphs for the heights of the previous example.




**Method · Estimating the median.** Under the assumption of uniformity in $[170, 180)$, the cumulative frequency rises linearly from 30% to 65%. Look for the abscissa corresponding to 50%.

**Example 15.** Calculate this estimate and state its scope.